

Taiwan crisis risk will rise after 2028

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【メール原文】

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Taiwan

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Beijing's growing confidence will heighten Taiwan risks after 2028

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The risk of an invasion of Taiwan will rise over the next five years as increasing Chinese capabilities and renewed military confidence shift Beijing's assessment of the costs.

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An invasion remains a remote but serious risk (10% starting in 2029), since Beijing believes it can achieve unification through methods short of military action—a mix of intense coercion and persuasion.

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The risk of a non-invasion crisis, such as a quarantine, will rise to 30% starting in 2029, with the US and Taiwanese governments elected in 2028 likely to adopt more confrontational policies toward China even as Beijing's expectations of acquiescence rise.

Odds of an invasion will rise over the next five years to 10%. President Xi Jinping's confidence in his military was shaken by purges that ousted about 80% of senior officers, but is likely to be restored by late 2027, when reconstruction of the Central Military Commission should be complete. By 2029, Beijing is also likely to believe that the military cost of an invasion is declining, and its sense of threat regarding Taiwan may heighten following elections in the US and Taiwan in 2028.

Military balance may shift in China's favor by 2031, though invasion would still have severe costs. The US is likely to retain its qualitative edge in some domains, such as undersea warfare. But China may widen its advantage in missile stockpiles and other systems built for a Taiwan contingency, including amphibious landing craft, integrated air defense, and electronic warfare. China's strong industrial base and the US need to rebuild from a post-Iran war deficit will likely bolster Beijing's position.

China is optimizing narrowly for a Taiwan scenario, while the US is modernizing for much broader global commitments. The pace and shape of defense build-up in Taiwan and the US will also depend on domestic politics. (see US interceptor gaps deepen Iran standoff but have limited Taiwan effect , 2 September 2026).

Nevertheless, an invasion would still be the riskiest means of achieving unification. A war would likely be economically catastrophic for China regardless of the outcome—disrupting trade, chip supply chains, and shipping through the Taiwan Strait. Washington could compound that damage with financial sanctions.

China's view of US decline boosts confidence in achieving unification without an invasion. Beijing believes Washington is increasingly unlikely to come to Taiwan's defense, improving the odds that China can compel unification through a mix of heavy coercion and persuasion. A prolonged quarantine of the island, alongside efforts to reduce US support to Taiwan, is one way Beijing could induce Taipei to enter negotiations about a political arrangement and pressure Taiwanese society to believe it must accept closer ties with China.

Beijing sees little risk of a formal change to Taiwan's status in the medium term, and Xi's legacy will require that he demonstrate progress toward unification, not completion. Such progress could take several forms, including de facto control of the waters around Taiwan, a new political understanding with Washington, or renewed efforts toward cross-strait economic integration.

The odds of a non-invasion crisis will rise considerably to 30% in 2029. After the 2028 presidential elections in the US and Taiwan, frictions between the US and China over Taiwan are likely to increase while cross-strait tensions will endure. Beijing will expect the next US administration to show continued restraint on Taiwan (see Trump will subordinate Taiwan arms sales to US-China stability , 19 May 2026), while President Donald Trump's successor is likely to be less accommodating than he has been (see Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031 , 27 August 2026). Regardless of its political orientation, the next administration is likely to engage in more regular arms sales, presidential transits, and engagements with Taiwan.

President William Lai currently looks likely to win a second term on the strength of the economy and divisions within the opposition. He will continue policies that reduce ties with China and Chinese influences in Taiwanese society—moves that Beijing views as hostile. Risks may rise in 2031, because the presidential campaign in Taiwan for the 2032 election and China's Party Congress in 2032 will create incentive to posture on both sides.

A quarantine is the biggest risk in the next five years. Beijing has expanded its non-military presence around Taiwan and sought information from commercial vessels in Taiwan's waters for the first time in June (see Beijing leveraging US truce to expand maritime control around Taiwan , 20 July 2026). There are several types of quarantines; Beijing is likely to move incrementally up its escalation ladder and opt for milder, more deniable action before turning to more intense options with greater market impact (see Strait of Hormuz closure offers lessons for China's Taiwan playbook , 19 March 2026). The scale of that impact also depends on how Washington responds—whether through sanctions and entity listings or an escort operation.

The watchpoints for a quarantine are actions or statements by the US or Taiwan that Beijing can use to justify escalation. Unprecedented US public support for Taiwan, such as involving Taiwan's military in annual RIMPAC exercises, or changes to Taiwan's laws that remove references to the idea that the two sides of the Taiwan Strait belong to "one China" are potential triggers.

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